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WHY AFRICA STILL MATTERS TO INDIA



■ India wants to diversify its energy basket and Africa still has large untapped oil reserves. African oil has low sulphur content and is cheaper to refine.

■ African countries like Gabon have uranium reserves that can fuel Indian reactors after the Nuclear Suppliers Group gives the nod.

■ Africa comprises biggest block of 54 member countries at the UN and is crucial for India's aspirations to be a permanent member of the UN Security Council.

Indian products. India is also looking to double trade with Africa and is expected to announce more scholarships and training slots for African professionals. Officials say besides enhancing economic ties, the summit would also bring out ideas to jointly address international challenges of terrorism and climate change, as well as UN reforms.

Then there is a strategic reason as well. Many African countries have big uranium reserves and India is already in discussion with countries like Gabon to source uranium once it gets a nod from the Nuclear Suppliers Group. East African countries like Kenya are key to its strategy to fight terrorism and ensure maritime security in the Indian Ocean region, and to put a leash on the mafia groups that have been using some of these countries as a safe haven. With 54 votes at major international forums such as the UN, African countries, particularly those that have been favourably disposed towards India, can also be a major support bank. The

Delhi summit would help. "India's relations with African nations are based on political understanding and a reservoir of goodwill and the summit will help in crystallising this partnership and open new pathways of cooperation between the two sides," says Anand Sharma, minister of state for external affairs.

India's renewed thrust at opening doors for Africa also lies in its desire to match up with neighbour and rival China's aggressive foray into Africa. China has been regularly holding high level visits to Africa and had held a major summit of African leaders in November 2006. It has pumped more than \$2.7 billion (Rs 10,800 crore) into Africa. India's current focus on Africa is strengthened by the fact that coupled with its traditional links, it can offer value-added skills in areas such as information technology. "Africa is India's natural partner, we have traditional and community links with the continent and it offers bright prospects for Indian business and trade. Besides it is

pivotal for our strategic interests," says Surendra Kumar, former Indian envoy to Kenya. With a 2.8-million-strong Indian diaspora, India is seeking to revitalise its traditional and community links with the continent.

While China has been undercutting India by offering lucrative defence packages, officials say riding on India's political goodwill and its equal partner approach, it will somehow manage to outsmart rivals like China. The two currently have a \$55-billion (Rs 2.20 lakh crore) trade link which is more than double India's trade with Africa. "We are keen to develop human resources and contribute to the progress of Africa which will lead to a win-win relationship as opposed to colonising of Africa by settling in Chinese workers there," explains a South Block source. Officials insist that India's engagement with Africa is different as compared to other countries. Indian aid has few strings attached to it. Besides, Indian assistance has a focus on sharing technology and expertise and helping Africa in areas of education and human resource development.

India is attempting to win the hearts and minds of Africans through big ticket development projects. Its Pan Africa eNetwork project will open up avenues for cooperation in the health-care sector. The project is India's visible symbol of cooperation in Africa which, at an estimated cost of around \$5 billion (Rs 20,000 crore), would use Indian expertise in information technology to bring benefits of healthcare and higher education. Besides this, India and Africa are exploring avenues for cooperation in agriculture, small and medium enterprises, water management, infrastructure, biotechnology, energy and climate change.

While India has made a beginning, albeit a bit late, it will have to work on a concerted strategy to engage Africa. It will have to finetune its aid policy which has had gaping holes, including allegations of corruption and misuse. It will also have to ensure that it opens more diplomatic outposts and convinces its brightest to serve in Africa to ensure proper diplomatic outreach. Unlike the past, when India had limited competition in Africa there are now many suitors willing to woo what was considered a dark continent. ■